Chiara Zanardello

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Research Interests

Innovation, economic history, human capital and education, migration, long-term growth

Academic Position

2025 – Present Postdoctoral Research Fellow **IAST-Toulouse School of Economics**

Doctoral Studies

2021 – 2025 Ph.D. in Economics **UCLouvain**
PhD Thesis: *Human Capital and Knowledge Networks: Market Forces, Scientific Academies, and the Spread of Ideas in Early Modern Europe.*
Supervisor: *David de la Croix*

Jan-Jun 2024 Visiting Graduate Fellow **Northwestern University**
Host advisor: *Joel Mokyr*

Pre-Doctoral Studies

2020 - 2021 M.Res. Economics (Joint Degree) **UCLouvain**
2019 - 2021 M.Sc. Economics and Political Science **University of Milan**
Fall 2018 Undergraduate Exchange Program (Erasmus+) **University of Latvia**
2016 - 2019 B.Sc. Economics and Commerce **University of Verona**

Publications

Zanardello, Chiara (2023). "Market forces in Italian Academia today (and yesterday)". In: *Scientometrics* 128, pp. 651–698. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/s11192-022-04579-0.

Working Papers

- Early Modern Academies, Universities, and Economic Growth
  LIDAM Discussion Paper - 2024/12
  Knowledge is central to modern economic growth, but what role did it play in the past? This paper studies whether Early Modern academies, research-oriented institutions that spread across Europe between 1650 and 1800, were associated with long-run growth. Using novel data on individual scholars, I show that academy creation was followed by higher urban population growth over the long run. This pattern is driven mainly by scientific academies, while literary academies show little evidence of comparable effects. Complementary analyses suggest that scientific academies were also linked to short-run positive spillovers to nearby cities and to improvements in local university quality. Overall, these findings provide new pan-European evidence consistent with scientific academies being part of Europe's long-run development.

- Flora, Cosmos, Salvatio: Pre-modern Academic Institutions and the Spread of Ideas
  (with David de la Croix, and Rossana Scebba) CEPR Discussion Paper - DP20569
  While good ideas can emerge anywhere, it takes a community to develop and disseminate them. In premodern Europe (1084-1793), there were approximately 200 universities and 150 academies of sciences, home to thousands of scholars from the Middle Ages to the First Industrial Revolution. By inferring co-presence from institutional affiliations, we simulate how ideas would spread from a scholar to another across the European academic network. We find that the implied exposure patterns align with observed urban developments: examples include botanic gardens, astronomical observatories, and Protestantism. Scholars' mobility and multiple affiliations sustain the diffusion, and counterfactual simulations underscore the bridging role played by scientific academies. We also show that the spread of ideas through the affiliation network was locally fragile but globally robust, pointing towards academia as being a connective infrastructure underlying early European development.
- The Geography of European Knowledge: 1000-1800

Work in Progress

- Counting Houses: Mapping Late Medieval Populations using the DOMUS Model *(with Christian Vedel)*
- How sustainable is the innovation process? *(with Ludovic Maisonneuve and Maxime Derex)*
- Destruction of Human Capital

Data Papers

2025 Fabre, Alice and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Académie des belles-lettres, sciences et arts in Marseille (1726–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

2024 Gualandris, Tifenn, Vitale, Mara, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Agiati Academy in Rovereto (1750–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Clément, Blandine, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Royal Naval Academy of France in Brest (1752–1793)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Zanardello, Chiara *Scholars and Literati at the Academy of Sciences, Letters and Arts of Arras (1737–1793)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

2023 Clément, Blandine, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Academy of Georgofili (1753 – 1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

de la Croix, David, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the University of Modena (1175–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Zanardello, Chiara *Literati and Scholars at the Dissonanti Academy in Modena (1680-1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

de la Croix, David, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars at the Royal Academy of Sciences in Paris (1666-1793)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

2022 **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Philosophical Society of Oxford (1651–1690)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Rolla, Cecilia, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Academy of Sciences of Bologna (1714–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Zanardello, Chiara *Scholars and Literati at the University of Turin (1404–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

2021 de la Croix, David, and **Zanardello, Chiara** *Scholars and Literati at the Academy of Sciences of Turin (1757–1800)*. Repertorium Eruditorum Totius Europae. [DOI]

Scholarships & Grants

2026	**Multidisciplinary Grant IAST**: co-P.I. with Ludovic Maisonneuve and Maxime Derex
2023	**Mobility scholarships**: Scientific Stay Grant (FRS-FNRS), and Travel Grant (FWB)
2023	**Ph.D. Fellowship** (within *PDR (FRS-FNRS)* – Main promoter: David de la Croix)
2021	**Ph.D. Fellowship** (within *ERC grant 883033* – Supervisor: David de la Croix)
2020	**Joint Degree Program UNIMI – UCLouvain**
2020, 2021	**Right to University Education (DSU)** (University of Milan)
2018	**Erasmus+ Study Abroad Program**
2017, 2018, 2019	**Right to University Education (DSU)** (University of Verona)

Teaching Experience

2025	*Using Economic Tools to Solve Global Challenges* (TA, Graduate)	**UCLouvain**
2023	*Advanced Macroeconomics III* (TA, Graduate)	**UCLouvain**

Talks

2026 ASSA 2026 (Philadelphia, USA), George Mason University (Fairfax, USA), ENCHOS VIII (Lyon, France), "Historical Human capital the age of big data" (Louvain-la-Neuve, Belgium), ASREC Europe 2026 (Venice, Italy)

2025 Université Laval (Quebec City, Canada), University of Sussex (Brighton, UK), Economic History Society (Glasgow, Scotland), AMSE PhD lunch seminar (Aix-Marseille University, France), IAST-TSE Welcome Days (Toulouse, France), IAST Lunch Seminar (Toulouse, France)

2024 Economic History Lunch (Northwestern University), Cliometric Society Conference (AU Washington DC), European Doctoral Program Jamboree (Pompeu Fabra University, Barcelona), FRESH workshop "Institutions, human capital, and long-term development: Lessons from pre-modern Europe" (UCLouvain), EHA "Globalization: Perspectives from the Past" (Sacramento, CA), CEPR-YSI (University of Southern Denmark)

2023 Doctoral Workshop (UCLouvain), IRES Lunch Seminar (UCLouvain), Econometric Society Winter Meeting (UManchester)

2022 IRES Lunch Seminar (UCLouvain), Conference "Early modern science, technology, and institutions" (UManchester), Doctoral Workshop (UCLouvain), AMSE Summer School "The Economics of Growth" (Aix-Marseille University), Conference "Religion, culture and economic growth in historical perspective"(UCLouvain)

References

David de la Croix
UCLouvain
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Joel Mokyr
Northwestern University
j-mokyr@northwestern.edu

Victor Gay
Toulouse School of Economics
victor.gay@tse-fr.eu

Miscellaneous

Refereeing	Journal of the European Economic Association, The Quarterly Journal of Economics
Services	Conference co-organization "Innovaition across Time, Space, and Societies" (IAST, 3-4 June 2027), co-organization IAST General Seminars (2026-2027), co-organization Doctoral seminars (UCLouvain, 2024-2025)
Digital Skills	R, Stata, LaTeX, TeamPortal, Matlab, EViews
Languages	Italian (mother tongue), English (advanced), French (advanced), German (basic)
Hobbies	Volleyball, Running

Last updated: October 27, 2026